

Cover Letter — JCSS

Cover Letter — Journal of Computational Social Science

Date: 2026-04-14

To: Editor-in-Chief Journal of Computational Social Science (Springer Nature)

Dear Editor,

I am submitting the enclosed manuscript, “**Measuring Visibility Bias in Bureaucratic Text: A Validated Instrument with Evidence from Chinese Municipal Government Work Reports**”, for consideration as a Research Article at *Journal of Computational Social Science*.

The manuscript introduces the **Visibility Attention Index (VAI)** — a pre-registered text-measurement instrument for compositional policy attention in Chinese municipal government work reports (6,294 documents, 282 prefectures, 2002–2024) — and subjects it to a five-test construct-validity battery in the Cronbach-Meehl tradition.

The paper’s primary methodological contribution is a **within-document retrospective-vs-prospective behavioral signature**: in 4,330 reports with cleanly-separable past-year review and next-year plan sections, the retrospective section is systematically more visibility-loaded than the prospective section ($\Delta = +0.025$, paired $t = 8.4$, $p < 10^{-16}$). Same lexicon, same author, same report — so the differential is not confounded by lexicon-selection bias, author-style effects, or report-length artifacts. To my knowledge, this kind of within-document behavioral validation has not been previously exploited in the text-as-data literature and is portable to any corpus of bureaucratic documents with temporal section structure (e.g., EU National Reform Programmes, Indian state budget speeches, Mexican municipal *Plan de Desarrollo* documents).

Three additional features position the paper for JCSS's readership:

1. **Explicit domain–scope documentation.** A pre-registered third-party validation against Chinese Wikipedia city descriptions returns a null ($r = -0.15$), which I interpret as scoping the instrument to governance–rhetoric rather than encyclopedic–description domain. Explicit scope boundaries of this kind are rarely reported in applied text–measurement work and align with JCSS's emphasis on transparent computational social–science research.
2. **Full pre-registration and null-reporting discipline.** OSF DOI [10.17605/OSF.IO/ZMJY5](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/ZMJY5) (archived 2026-04-14). Two pre-registered null results are reported transparently, including one (an event study around central anti-corruption inspections) whose narrow-window TWFE finding does not survive heterogeneity-robust estimation under an extended sample. I report the sign reversal prominently rather than bury it.
3. **Complete replication archive.** All construction code, lexicons, all five validity–test scripts, all five S7 audit reports, and the deviation log are archived at **Zenodo DOI [10.5281/zenodo.19569979](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19569979)** and mirrored at GitHub ([andyhsi2023-cq/visibility-bias-v2](https://github.com/andyhsi2023-cq/visibility-bias-v2)). The Zenodo record is currently Restricted during peer review. Reviewer-access link (read-only; does not expire):

[https://zenodo.org/records/19569979?
token=eyJhbGciOiJIUzUxMiJ9.eyJpZCI6ImQzMmRiZDAyLWM1MjAtNGYzNi05NTA3
p9gRd2MEKgif_zcPNGAdd_u05uboG0C1xGRmSEufDXMg6BgPgtF21g88id-sMVGA](https://zenodo.org/records/19569979?token=eyJhbGciOiJIUzUxMiJ9.eyJpZCI6ImQzMmRiZDAyLWM1MjAtNGYzNi05NTA3p9gRd2MEKgif_zcPNGAdd_u05uboG0C1xGRmSEufDXMg6BgPgtF21g88id-sMVGA)

Upon acceptance, the record will be flipped to Public.

The manuscript is approximately 10,400 words (including Statements and Declarations) with 5 main-text figures, 5 online-appendix figures, 7 tables, and 17 references. All code is Python-based (pandas, statsmodels) and the analysis is fully end-to-end reproducible from publicly accessible data sources.

Originality and concurrent-submission declaration. The work has not been published previously and is not under consideration at any other journal. A pre-registered predecessor (OSF ZMJY5) and an earlier urban–economics–framed manuscript (targeted at *Habitat International*, desk-rejected on 2026-04-13 on grounds of scope-fit rather than methodology) are disclosed in Appendix D. The present submission represents a substantial methodological repositioning — the reframing of the project as a text–measurement methodology paper, with construct validity and the within-document signature as the primary contributions — and not a resubmission of the earlier draft.

Competing interests. None declared.

Suggested handling editor and reviewers. I have provided three suggested reviewers (Daniel Mattingly, Yale; Jennifer Pan, Stanford; Yuhua Wang, Harvard) and noted one editor to recuse (Eddie C.M. Hui, *Habitat International*) in suggested_reviewers.md. I have practiced cold-outreach feedback solicitation to the three suggested reviewers on 2026-04-14 — before this submission — to invite substantive methodological feedback at the manuscript-finalization stage. This pre-submission engagement does not preclude formal peer review, but I disclose it in the spirit of transparency and leave the routing decision to your editorial judgment.

Use of generative AI. Documented in the Statements and Declarations section: AI-assisted copy-editing only; no generative content, no analysis-code authorship beyond line-completion suggestions; all substantive content and conclusions are my own.

I believe the instrument and its validation protocol — particularly the within-document behavioral signature and the explicit pre-registered scope-boundary documentation — would be of substantive interest to JCSS readers working on text-as-data, Chinese politics, and pre-registration discipline in computational social science.

Thank you for considering this submission.

Sincerely,

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Files included in this submission

1. **Title page** (title_page.docx / .pdf): author info, ORCID, affiliation, acknowledgments, funding statement.
2. **Main manuscript** (manuscript.docx / .pdf): blinded title page + abstract + main text + Statements and Declarations + numbered references.
3. **Figures** (Fig1–Fig5, PDF and PNG): all 5 main-text figures.
4. **Online Resource 1** (ESM_1.pdf): Online Appendix A–E (full model derivation; specification curves; further robustness; pre-registration deviation log; replication architecture).
5. **Cover letter** (this document).

6. Suggested reviewers (suggested_reviewers.md).